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PII: S2451-9022(17)30234-3

DOI: [10.1016/j.bpsc.2017.12.004](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.bpsc.2017.12.004)

Reference: BPSC 225

To appear in: *Biological Psychiatry: Cognitive Neuroscience and Neuroimaging*

Received Date: 23 August 2017

Revised Date: 20 November 2017

Accepted Date: 10 December 2017

Please cite this article as: Khalsa S.S., Adolphs R., Cameron O.G., Critchley H.D., Davenport P.W., Feinstein J.S., Feusner J.D., Garfinkel S.N., Lane R.D., Mehling W.E., Meuret A.E., Nemeroff C.B., Oppenheimer S., Petzschner F.H., Pollatos O., Rhudy J.L., Schramm L.P., Simmons W.K., Stein M.B., Stephan K.E., Van Den Bergh O., Van Diest I., von Leupoldt A., Paulus M.P. & the Interoception Summit 2016 participants, Interoception and Mental Health: a Roadmap, *Biological Psychiatry: Cognitive Neuroscience and Neuroimaging* (2018), doi: 10.1016/j.bpsc.2017.12.004.

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Interoception and Mental Health: a Roadmap

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Keywords:

Interoception; mental health; biomarker; Research Domain Criteria (RDoC),
computational psychiatry; treatment

Article information:

Running title: Interoception and mental health

Type of submission: Review

Number of words:

Abstract: 203 out of 250

Manuscript: 3994 out of 4000

Number of figures: 4

Number of tables: 3

Number of supplementary materials: 1

Number of references: 150 out of 150

Abstract

Interoception refers to the process by which the nervous system senses, interprets, and integrates signals originating from within the body, providing a moment-by-moment mapping of the body's internal landscape across conscious and unconscious levels. Interoceptive signaling has been considered a component process of reflexes, urges, feelings, drives, adaptive responses, cognitive and emotional experiences, highlighting its contributions to the maintenance of homeostatic functioning, body regulation, and survival. Dysfunction of interoception is increasingly recognized as an important component of different mental health conditions including anxiety disorders, mood disorders, eating disorders, addictive disorders, somatic symptom disorders, and others. However, a number of conceptual and methodological challenges have made it difficult for interoceptive constructs to be broadly applied in mental health research and treatment settings. In November 2016, the Laureate Institute for Brain Research organized the first Interoception Summit, a gathering of interoception experts from around the world, with the goal of accelerating progress in understanding the role of interoception in mental health. The discussions at the meeting were organized around four themes: interoceptive assessment, interoceptive integration, interoceptive psychopathology, and the generation of a roadmap that could serve as a guide for future endeavors. This article presents an overview of the emerging consensus generated by the meeting.

Introduction

Interoception refers collectively to the processing of internal bodily stimuli by the nervous system. Parcellation of the nervous system's processing of sensory signals into interoception, proprioception, and exteroception began more than a hundred years ago (1), although it was predated by interest in linking body-brain interactions with conscious experience (2, 3). Scientific interest in interoception has fluctuated (Figure 1A). In the 1980's biological psychiatry was inundated with observations of interoceptive disturbances in panic disorder (4-7), though the trend receded after it became clear that the etiological mechanism was broader than a single molecular receptor target (8). Recent years have witnessed a surge of interest on the topic of interoception, due in part to findings highlighting its integral role in emotional experience, self-regulation, decision-making, and consciousness. Importantly, interoception is not limited to conscious perception or even unique to the human species. From this perspective, interdisciplinary efforts to understand different features of interoception have been essential for advancing progress in cognitive and clinical neuroscience (Figure 1B).

< Insert Figure 1 about here >

I. Assessment

Body systems of interoception

Interoceptive processing occurs across all major biological systems involved in maintaining bodily homeostasis, including the cardiovascular (10, 11), pulmonary (12), gastrointestinal (13, 14), genitourinary (15), nociceptive (16), chemosensory (17),

osmotic (18), thermoregulatory (19), visceral¹ (20), immune (24, 25), and autonomic systems (26, 27) (**Table 1**). There has been relatively little focus overall on the integration across bodily systems, thus it is not surprising that most investigations of the topic have been siloed within distinct research areas or scientific disciplines (see (28) and (29) for noteworthy exceptions).

< Insert Table 1 about here >

Features of interoception

Interoception is not a simple process but rather has several facets (30). The act of sensing, interpreting, and integrating information about the state of inner body systems can be related to different elements such as interoceptive attention, detection, discrimination, accuracy, insight, sensibility, and self-report (**Table 2**). However, most interoceptive processes occur outside the realm of conscious awareness. Consciously experienced elements are measured clinically via subjective report, and there are few observable interoceptive signs (e.g., heart rate, respiration rate, pupillary dilation, flushing, perspiration, piloerection, nociceptive reflexes) (**Table 3**). Experimental approaches can quantify different body systems and features of interoceptive processing. Nevertheless, these measures are only partially overlapping and likely reflect somewhat distinct neural

¹ Visceroception has classically referred to the perception of bodily signals arising specifically from visceral organs such as the heart, lungs, stomach, intestines, and bladder, along with other internal organs in the trunk of the body (20). It did not include organs like the skin or skeletal muscle, in contrast to contemporary definitions interoception which typically encompasses signals from both the viscera and all other tissues that relay a signal to the central nervous system about the current state of the body, including the skin and skeletal/smooth muscle fibers, via lamina I spinothalamic afferents (21-23).

processes (31). Access to the full range of interoceptive signals often involves invasive approaches, which tend to elicit physiological perturbations and index more objectively measurable features (32). However, many insights have been gained by the application of non-invasive approaches within neuroscience and psychological assessment contexts (33) (see “Eavesdropping on brain-body communication”).

< Insert Table 2 about here >

Importance of an interoceptive taxonomy

There is no generally agreed-upon taxonomy for interoception science. Variable definitions have made it difficult to identify the features under investigation, let alone evaluate the quality of the findings. Based on the number of physiological systems involved, it could be questioned whether the terms “interoception” and “interoceptive awareness” are too broad. Interoceptive awareness is an umbrella term that was first used to describe a self-report subscale (34), but has subsequently been used to encompass any (or all) of the different interoception features accessible to conscious self-report. Researchers from different fields developed definitions that only partially overlapped reflecting the need for operationalization in neuroscience (35, 36) and clinical practice (9, 37). Here we develop a more coherent nomenclature for its various components (**Table 2**), mirroring developments in other fields, especially pain (38). One key aspect is the importance of distinguishing sensation (i.e., the “raw” signals conveyed by bodily sensors) from perception (39, 40). We return to this theme below.

< Insert Table 3 about here >

Multilevel investigations

While interoception research to date has typically focused on single organ systems, a expanded approach is called for that assesses multiple interoceptive organ systems or elements. Examples include targeting numerous interoceptive features simultaneously, or employing different tasks which converge upon the same feature (e.g., combining ‘top-down’ assessments of interoceptive attention with ‘bottom-up’ perturbation approaches in the same individual) (**Figure 2A**).

Sensing perturbations

The inner and outer worlds of the body constantly fluctuate. The nervous system monitors these environmental changes and responds adaptively in order to maintain a homeostatic balance and promote survival. As psychiatric disorders often promote or reflect the development of chronic homeostatic and allostatic disturbances (61) there is a need for methods capable of eliciting homeostatic perturbations in controlled settings, especially those assessing subjective and behavioral responses to valence and arousal deviations. However, interoception is not simply about afferent processing. The brain’s constant monitoring of the body occurs in service of optimizing homeostatic regulation. This efferent limb is understudied (62), and paradigms which can effectively measure visceromotor outputs will be critical to establish sensitive assays of dysfunctional

interoception and homeostatic regulation (e.g., detection of visceromotor-efferent neural signals controlling baroreflex sensitivity during modulation of visceral-afferent input by sympathetic drugs). The reliability and validity of methods should be rigorously established.

< Insert Figure 2 about here >

II. Integration

Interoception and domain specificity within the brain

There are fundamentally differing ways to interpret the evolution of brain and body signaling in humans. The processing of interoceptive input could be domain specific, with modular processing occurring in specialized, encapsulated neural circuits (e.g. cardiac, respiratory, urinary, genital, chemical, hormonal; see (63) for a review of domain specificity), or functionally coupled (e.g., cardio-respiratory, genito-urinary, chemo-hormonal) and integrated within a single neural circuit. Understanding the adaptive origins and functions of interoceptive domain specificity (if present) could tell us how the implementation and deployment of interoceptive signals by the nervous system contributes to disordered mental health. Since interoceptive signaling involves afferent and efferent inputs across multiple hierarchies within the autonomic and central nervous systems, identifying where and how information processing dysfunctions negatively impact mental health represents a challenging problem.

Neural pathways of interoception

Several pathways have been implicated in the neural processing of interoceptive signals, beginning with a rich interface between autonomic afferents and the central nervous system. Relay pathways involve primarily spinal, vagal, and glossopharyngeal afferents, with multiple levels of processing and integration in autonomic ganglia and spinal cord (11, 20, 23, 26). Several brainstem (nucleus of the solitary tract, parabrachial nucleus, periaqueductal gray), subcortical (thalamus, hypothalamus, hippocampus, amygdala), and cortical regions (insula and somatosensory cortices) represent key afferent processing regions (26, 64, 65). A complementary set of regions involved in visceromotor actions represent key efferent processing regions including the anterior insula, anterior cingulate, subgenual cingulate, orbitofrontal, ventromedial prefrontal, supplementary motor and premotor areas (66-68). It is noteworthy that these neural regions coincide closely with other sensory processing systems, especially the nociceptive and affective systems. The degree to which these represent distinct or overlapping systems is presently unclear.

Linking paradigms across units of analysis

A particular challenge when examining interoception is the fact that afferent sensory signals are integrated on several levels (peripherally, within the spinal cord, and supra-spinally) to form sets of interoceptive maps across different body systems. The brain appears to integrate information representing particular states of multiple systems simultaneously (cardiac, respiratory, chemical, hormonal, nociceptive etc.) (23), and it is imperative to be able to model and comparatively evaluate such mappings (**Figure 2B**). This poses many challenges. One approach might be to apply measures which assess multiple organ systems or interoceptive features simultaneously (see (64, 69, 70)), or to

record activity across the brain, spinal cord and peripheral organs (71). However, it is also possible that multi-system assessments may reduce specificity for certain disorders, and may therefore be unnecessary. For example, some panic disorder patients may experience dyspnea but not palpitations. Localizing and then targeting the dysfunctional interoceptive domain would become more useful than broad multisystem interventions.

Timing and rhythm in interoceptive circuits

The physiological timescales and amplitudes of interoceptive signaling vary dramatically (e.g., heart rate (0.5-3.3 Hz), respiratory rate (0.08-1 Hz), gastric contractility (0.05-0.1 Hz), urinary frequency (0.000045-0.00012 Hz), with even slower changes in humoral mediators (Harrison & Savitz, special issue) (**Figure 2C and 2D**)). They also vary across individuals, and over the life-span (e.g. increased heart rates in infants/children). Despite the variance the brain tracks such changes in similar subregions including the insula, somatosensory cortices, cingulate, amygdala, thalamus and brainstem (64, 65, 72-74). Temporal synchrony or dys-synchrony between these systems may impact interoceptive experiences, affect, and behavior, although the exact mechanisms require further study (75). Repetitive events are another important element for learning, and while there are numerous classic studies on visceral learning at the peripheral organ system level (76, 77), we know little about the central mapping of learned visceral memories especially in psychiatric disorders (Simmons et al. special issue).

How can animal research improve the understanding of human interoceptive processing?

Although the inability to measure the subjective state of animals results in indirect inferences, well established tasks exist (e.g., conditioned interoceptive place preference (78) and odor aversion (79)). The principal utility of animal models is the hypothesis testing of mechanistic processes at the biological level independent of appraisal and cognition. These include examining effects of peripheral or central nervous system lesions on physiology/behavior, or mapping of peripheral/central interactions via stimulation of selective neurons/circuits using optogenetic methods (80, 81), and targeted gene expression manipulation to test genetic hypotheses (82). Animal models are advantageous in that they allow for identification of neural mechanisms that may be distinct from higher cognitive processes (e.g., non-mammalian (reptiles/birds) vs. mammalian (mice/rats/monkeys/apes/chimpanzees), invertebrate (octopus) vs. vertebrate (fish/monkeys)). The study of interoception in non-human primates offers intriguing opportunities. Investigations in this area have been centered primarily on neural encoding of baroreceptor afferent stimulation (10) and neuroanatomical circuit tracing (83). Fewer studies have examined relationships between mechanistic manipulation of interoceptive experiences and neural representation in these animals (see (84, 85) for exceptions).

Eavesdropping on brain-body communications

Interoception is manifested by the conversation between the body and brain, via multiple afferent and efferent feedback loops (23, 86). Listening in on this process requires different approaches. Peripheral perturbations are often used to stimulate the afferent bottom-up transfer of information, usually of mechanical (32, 69, 73, 74), chemical (87-89), or hormonal origin (90) (**Supplementary Table 1**). Central perturbations to probe

efferent top-down processes have most typically involved selective regulation of attentional focus (33, 91), and less commonly, expectancy manipulations such as placebo/sham delivery (46). Functional magnetic resonance imaging (92), positron emission tomography (93), and electroencephalography (94, 95), have provided the primary means of assessing neural circuitry. However, a host of novel tools are capable of inhibiting, stimulating, or modulating the activity of interoceptive brain networks. Non-invasive methods include the application of transcranial magnetic stimulation (96), transcranial direct and alternating current stimulation (97), low-intensity focused ultrasound (98), temporally interfering electric fields (99), transcutaneous vagus nerve stimulation (tVNS) (100), presentation of information during different phases of visceral rhythms (e.g., cardiac systole vs. diastole) (101), and assessment of corticocardiac signaling (102). An important point is that many of the critical brain structures are difficult to modulate non-invasively as they are located deep within the brain or near the midline. Invasive measures do not share this limitation; and while their implementation is driven by clinical concerns, they can provide important insights. These include implanted VNS (103), direct brain stimulation (104), and intracranial electrode recordings (105, 106). Beyond these perturbation tools, the use of experimental methods to modulate expectancies, such as placebo and sham interventions, are key. These methods will help determine how sensitive psychiatric and other clinical patients' afferent/efferent feedback loops are to processes requiring integrations of environmental context with body-brain signals (illustrated in the next section). Finally, neurofeedback (e.g., fMRI/EEG) represents an exciting opportunity to participate in the brain-body conversation by simultaneously measuring and modulating brain regions during treatment (for a non-

interoceptive example, see (107)). Equipped with these tools, the future looks promising, but to advance progress they need to be paired with better models of brain function.

Computational theories of interoception

Identifying the state of the body represents a problem that cannot be solved by pure sensing, since afferent signals from body sensors (interosensations) are not only noisy but often ambiguous (108). Recent computational theories suggest that interoception deploys Bayesian inference to address this challenge (39, 40, 66, 67, 109, 110) (**Figure 3 and 4**). Specifically, the brain is assumed to construct a so-called “generative model” of interosensations that combines a predictive mapping (from hidden bodily states to interosensations) with prior information (beliefs or expectations about bodily states, represented as probability distributions). This view is supported by findings that interoceptive perception is strongly shaped by expectations (23, 46, 111, 112), and by theoretical arguments that suggest Bayesian inference as a unifying principle for intero- and exteroception (40, 110).

< **Insert Figure 3 about here** >

Another argument supporting a Bayesian view on interoception is its relation to what constitutes arguably the brain’s most fundamental task: the regulation (or control) of bodily states. Put simply, if the brain were unable to resolve the ambiguity of interosensations it would face difficulties in choosing appropriate actions to protect homeostasis. In information-theoretic terms, the challenge of keeping bodily states within

narrow homeostatic ranges corresponds to choosing actions that minimize the long-term average Shannon surprise (entropy) of interoceptions (39, 110). Solving this control problem requires knowledge or estimations of current and/or future bodily states and hence inference and predictions/forecasts—two natural domains of generative models.

Eliciting surprise-minimizing (homeostasis-restoring) actions changes the bodily state and thus interoceptions. This means that inference and control of bodily states form a closed loop. Inference-control loops that minimize interoceptive surprise can be cast as hierarchical Bayesian models (HBMs). Anatomically, HBMs are plausible candidates given that interoceptive circuitry is structured hierarchically (67, 113). Under general assumptions, HBMs employ a small set of computational quantities – predictions, prediction errors, and precisions (40, 114). These quantities can support surprise-minimization in two ways: by adjusting beliefs (probability distributions) throughout the hierarchy (predictive coding (114)), or engaging actions that fulfil beliefs about bodily states (active inference (115)).

HBMs support both homeostatic (reactive) and allostatic (prospective) control. Reconsidering classical homeostatic setpoints as beliefs (i.e., probabilistic representations of expected/desired bodily states) enables reactive regulation at the bottom of the hierarchy (39, 110): here, prediction errors elicit reflex-like actions that minimize momentary interoceptive surprise. Allostatic regulation at longer time-scales is achieved through modulation of homeostatic beliefs by inferred or forecast states signaled from higher hierarchical levels (39). Importantly, belief precision determines the force/pace of

corrective actions – that is, the tighter the expected range of bodily state, the more vigorous the elicited regulatory action. This offers a novel explanation for psychosomatic phenomena and placebo effects (40).

In summary, a hierarchical Bayesian perspective unifies interoception and homeostatic/allostatic control under the same computational principles. This provides a conceptual foundation for computational psychosomatics and supports a taxonomy of disease processes (40). One caveat is that the empirical evidence for hierarchical Bayesian principles of interoception and homeostatic/allostatic control is indirect so far. Studies designed to probe hierarchical Bayesian processes under experimentally controlled homeostatic perturbations will be crucial for finessing (or refuting) current computational concepts of interoception.

< Insert Figure 4 about here >

III. Psychopathology

Interoceptive psychopathology

Several conceptual and heuristic models have linked dysfunctions of interoception to mental health conditions. Specifically, mood and anxiety disorders have been linked to failures to appropriately anticipate changes in interoceptive states (116). Eating disorders show behavioral and neural abnormalities in interoceptive processing, particularly in the context of caloric anticipation (46, 47, 117, 118), although it remains unclear whether this is due to altered afferent signaling, altered central sensory processing, abnormal

temperament, and/or metacognition. Drug addiction, another condition marked by interoceptive disturbances, has an overlapping neural circuitry and abnormal responses to interoceptive cues (50, 119-121). Interoceptive dysfunction also likely plays a role in conditions including posttraumatic stress disorder and somatic symptom disorders (9). Other disorders also have interoceptive symptom overlap, however, the specific feature involved may differ according to the disorder or affected individual (e.g., chronic pain (122, 123), Tourette's syndrome and other Tic disorders, borderline personality disorder, obsessive compulsive disorder, autism spectrum disorder (58), and functional developmental disorders (124)). **Table 3** lists diagnostic symptoms and clinical signs indicative of interoceptive dysfunction in several psychiatric disorders. Conditions which have a psychiatric component include fibromyalgia, chronic fatigue syndrome, irritable bowel syndrome (IBS), functional disorders within medicine (e.g., non-cardiac chest pain, functional dysphagia), as well as certain medical disorders (e.g., gastroesophageal reflux, asthma).

Alternatively, one can use a dimensional psychopathology approach to link processes underlying interoceptive dysfunction to psychiatric disorders. Transdiagnostic perspectives such as those provided by the research domain criteria (RDoC) (125) may be particularly helpful in identifying the potential role played by various interoceptive processes, as several of these may not be readily identified at the symptom report level relied upon by clinicians, and accordingly, may not have entered into the diagnostic specifications for DSM. This would allow for identification of mechanistic dysfunctions across units of analyses and might bridge the biological gap in current diagnostic

classification frameworks by directly probing the links between physiological and psychological dysfunctions. Interoceptive investigations in mental health populations might reveal evidence of 1) attentional bias (e.g., hypervigilance), 2) distorted physiological sensitivity (e.g., blunted or heightened magnitude estimation in response to a perturbation), 3) cognitive bias (e.g., catastrophizing in response to an anticipated stimulus), 4) abnormal sensibility (e.g., tendency to label one's experiences in a particular way), and 5) impaired insight (e.g., poor confidence-accuracy correspondence on a task).

Determining whether interoceptive processes are a cause or consequence of developmental psychopathology, and which factors might impact this development (such as early life stress or pain), will be an important area for future research. Such studies may benefit from the examination of younger (126, 127) or older (128, 129) samples, premorbid identification and longitudinal tracking of individuals (130). Investigating the role of social cognition/theory of mind in clinically-relevant interoceptive inference generation represents another ripe opportunity (131).

Interoceptive tests and/or biomarkers

Since interoception is fundamentally a process linking body and brain, it is conceivable that objective measures of this process could serve as biological indicators of disease states. However, there is presently limited evidence for interoceptive predictors of diagnostic, prognostic, or treatment status (9, 132, 133). Biomarkers, such as those derived from neuroimaging or blood measurements, should be sensitive, specific, and unaffected by cognitive and emotional influences. However, it seems conceivable that the

most clinically sensitive interoceptive measures might derive from probes which perturb physiological functions to engage specific metacognitive beliefs and/or expectations about bodily states. Such measures could facilitate differential diagnosis testing by revealing the presence of interoceptive dysfunction of biological (within a physiological system or systems), psychological (e.g., overly precise expectations about bodily states), or metacognitive (e.g., discrepant self-efficacy beliefs with regard to homeostatic/allostatic regulation) origin (40). This approach could be seen as analogous to a cardiac stress test, such that adequate engagement of the system under ecologically valid conditions is required in order to measure its dysfunction.

The most common application of interoceptive evaluation in current clinical practice occurs during interoceptive exposure psychotherapy for panic disorder (134). During this procedure patients self-induce varieties of interoceptive symptoms via low-arousal manipulations (hyperventilation, performing jumping jacks, spinning in a chair, breathing through a straw) while the clinician monitors their subjective distress level. Unfortunately these manipulations often fail to adequately reproduce the fear response, possibly because the patient retains full control over the stimulation (they can quit at any time) and the perturbation remains predictable with minimal uncertainty, raising the question of whether modulating both physiological homeostasis *and* the perception of controllability might further improve the ecological validity and efficacy of interoceptive exposures (135). A test to verify successful interoceptive exposure therapy for panic disorder involves completion of a standardized behavioral avoidance paradigm (136). In this setting, the degree of tolerance to being enclosed in a small dark chamber for ten minutes

might provide behavioral evidence verifying tolerance to triggers of interoceptive dysregulation. There is also experimental evidence that pharmacological interoceptive exposure therapy can reduce anxiety disorder symptom severity either as monotherapy (7, 137-139) or as an augmentative approach (140). However, there are few studies of these procedures to date, the impact of such interventions on longer term outcomes (e.g., 6 months or beyond) are unknown, and none of these approaches have translated into clinical practice.

Current treatments relevant to interoception

Currently available therapies with an interoceptive basis include: 1) Pharmacotherapies directly modulating interoceptive physiology. Examples include adrenergic blockade (e.g., propranolol), or agonism (e.g., yohimbine), stimulants (e.g., methylphenidate), benzodiazepines, muscle relaxants, opioids, and others. 2) Cognitive behavioral therapy with exposure and response prevention to reverse or attenuate conditioned fears or form new learned associations. It is helpful in ameliorating cognitive biases in numerous disorders including depression, OCD, PTSD (specifically, prolonged exposure therapy), IBS, and chronic pain. Interoceptive exposure is a special example demonstrated to be highly effective in specific disorders (especially panic disorder). Behavioral activation therapy for depression sometimes includes exposure to experiences with positive interoceptive value. 3) Capnometry-assisted respiratory training. Based on the assumption that sustained hypocapnia resulting from hyperventilation is a key mechanism in the production and maintenance of panic, CO₂ capnography assisted therapy aims to help patients voluntarily increase end-tidal partial pressure of carbon dioxide and tolerate

physiological variability associated with panic attacks (141) (Meuret et al., special issue).

4) Mindfulness based stress reduction, yoga, and other meditation/movement based treatments may be aimed at improving metacognitive awareness of mind body connections, by systematically attending to sensations of breathing, cognitions, and/or other modulated body states (e.g., muscle stretching) (142).

Interoceptive treatments on the horizon

Several emerging technologies may have relevance for interoception and mental health.

1) Floatation-REST (Reduced Environmental Stimulation Therapy), an intervention which systematically attenuates exteroceptive sensory input to the nervous system, also appears to non-invasively enhance exposure to interoceptive sensations such as the breath and heartbeat (Feinstein et al., special issue). Preliminary data suggests that a single one-hour session has a short-term anxiolytic and antidepressant effect in patients with comorbid anxiety and depression (143), but further research is needed to evaluate the safety, feasibility, and potential for long-term efficacy in psychiatric populations.

2) Perturbation approaches. Minimally invasive tools capable of systematically modulating interoceptive processing, such as inspiratory breathing loads (144), core body thermomodulation (145, 146), and tVNS (147) are several approaches awaiting further investigation. Given the hypothesis of noisy baseline afferent signaling, these approaches may systematically enhance the signal-to-noise ratio and facilitate interoceptive learning. A key aspect in discerning clinical efficacy of any perturbation may be the extent to which the patient perceives controllability over the intervention, and is willing/able to

surrender this parameter in treatment. Interventions in which escape or active avoidance behaviors are directly measurable may provide especially meaningful information (Panefarre et al, special issue).

IV. Roadmap

The road ahead

Beyond the issues outlined previously, progress in determining the relevance of interoception for mental health relies upon emphasizing the features that distinguish it from other sensory modalities. Interoception seemingly involves a high degree of connectivity within the brain (148). It appears to be tightly linked to the self and survival through homeostatic maintenance of the body, and by helping us to represent how things are going in the present with respect to the experienced past and the anticipated future. These computations may depend on what has occurred to shape the body's internal landscape, and it is in this regard that learning, and malleability of representations over time, could play important roles.

The conceptual framework for investigating interoception may overlap with other processes, including emotion (149) and pain (150), as each is integral for maintaining bodily homeostasis. An important endeavor may involve the identification of which neural systems for interoception, emotion, cognition, and pain are overlapping, interdigitating, or even possibly identical. Additional effort is needed to define the neurophysiological nomenclature, core criteria, common features, developmental aspects,

modulating factors, functional consequences, and putative pathophysiologic mechanisms of interoception in mental health disorders.

The present work offers some conceptual distinctions and some mutually agreed upon terminology, with many others still needed. Several “low hanging fruits” have been mentioned, as well as promising emerging technologies and tools. Further empirical work will be critical to delineate how interoception can be mapped to mental health measures, models, and approaches, and benchmarks for success/failure need to be established. Models of interoceptive processing have been described which improve upon the traditional stimulus, sensorimotor processing, and response function concepts, but these models remain theoretical and await further testing. The current document is therefore best viewed as a work in progress.

Acknowledgments: The authors would like to express their sincere appreciation to The William K. Warren Foundation for supporting the Interoception Summit 2016, and to all of the Laureate Institute for Brain Research (LIBR) staff for their assistance with facilitating the meeting. Interoception Summit 2016 participant co-authors: Vivien Ainley, Obada Al Zoubi, Robin Aupperle, Jason Avery, Leslie Baxter, Christoph Benke, Laura Berner, Jerzy Bodurka, Eric Breese, Tiffany Brown, Kaiping Burrows, Yoon-Hee Cha, Ashley Clausen, Danielle Deville, Laramie Duncan, Patrice Duquette, Hamed Ekhtiari, Thomas Fine, Bart Ford, Indira Garcia Cordero, Diamond Gleghorn, Yvette Guereca, Mahlega Hassanpour, Tanja Hechler, Aaron Heller, Natalie Hellman, Beate Herbert, Behnaz Jarrahi, Kara Kerr, Namik Kirlic, Megan Klabunde, Thomas Kraynak, Michael Kriegsman, Juliet Kroll, Rayus Kuplicki, Rachel Lapidus, Trang Le, Kyle Logie Hagen, Ahmad Mayeli, Amanda Morris, Nasir Naqvi, Kristina Oldroyd, Raquel Phillips, Tasha Poppa, William Potter, Maria Puhl, Adam Safron, Margaret Sala, Jonathan Savitz, Heather Saxon, Will Schoenhals, Colin Stanwell-Smith, Adam Teed, Yuri Terasawa, Katie Thompson, Marisa Toups, Satoshi Umeda, Valerie Upshaw, Teresa Victor, Christina Wierenga, Colleen Wohlrab, Hung-wen Yeh, Adrian Yoris, Fadel Zeidan, Vadim Zotev, Nancy Zucker. SSK acknowledges support by The William K. Warren Foundation, a Brain and Behavior Foundation (formerly NARSAD) Young Investigator Award, the National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH) Award Number K23MH112949, and the National Institute of General Medical Sciences NIH/NIGMS P20GM121312. The content is solely the responsibility of the authors and does not necessarily represent the official views of the National Institutes of Health.

Disclosure statement: AEM reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants:

National Institutes of Health (NIH) 1U01EB021952-01. Consulting (last three years):

none. Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: Anxiety and Depression

Association of America. Board of Directors: none. Patents: none. Speakers Bureau: none.

AvL reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: Research Fund KU Leuven,

Belgium (STRT/13/002 and DBOF/14/021); an infrastructure grant from the

Herculesstichting, Belgium (AKUL/13/07); 'Asthenes' long-term structural funding

Methusalem grant (METH/15/011) by the Flemish Government, Belgium. Consulting

(last three years): none. Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: none. Board of

Directors: none. Patents: none. Speakers Bureau: none. CBN reports the following

disclosures: Research/Grants: National Institutes of Health (NIH), Stanley Medical

Research Institute. Consulting (last three years): Xhale, Takeda, Taisho Pharmaceutical

Inc., Prismic Pharmaceuticals, Bracket (Clintara), Total Pain Solutions (TPS), Gerson

Lehrman Group (GLG) Healthcare & Biomedical Council, Fortress Biotech, Sunovion

Pharmaceuticals Inc., Sumitomo Dainippon Pharma, Janssen Research & Development

LLC, Magstim, Inc., Navitor Pharmaceuticals, Inc., TC MSO, Inc. Stockholder: Xhale,

Celgene, Seattle Genetics, Abbvie, OPKO Health, Inc., Bracket Intermediate Holding

Corp., Network Life Sciences Inc., Antares. Scientific Advisory Boards: American

Foundation for Suicide Prevention (AFSP), Brain and Behavior Research Foundation

(BBRF) (formerly named National Alliance for Research on Schizophrenia and

Depression [NARSAD]), Xhale, Anxiety and Depression Association of America

(ADAA), Skyland Trail, Bracket (Clintara), RiverMend Health LLC, Laureate Institute

for Brain Research, Inc. Board of Directors: AFSP, Gratitude America, ADAA. Income sources or equity of \$10,000 or more: American Psychiatric Publishing, Xhale, Bracket (Clintara), CME Outfitters, Takeda. Patents: Method and devices for transdermal delivery of lithium (US 6,375,990B1). Method of assessing antidepressant drug therapy via transport inhibition of monoamine neurotransmitters by ex vivo assay (US 7,148,027B2). Speakers Bureau: None. HDC reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: European Research Council Horizon 2020 Proof of Concept Grant “HeartRater: Tools for the systematic evaluation of interoceptive ability.” Medical Research Council (UK) MRC Confidence in Concept Grant “Identifying neural, cognitive, and phenomenological markers of auditory verbal hallucinations in Borderline Personality.” MQ (Mental Health) PsyImpact “Aligning Dimensions of Interoceptive Experience (ADIE) to prevent development of anxiety disorders in autism.” Dr Mortimer and Theresa Sackler Foundation Sackler Centre for Consciousness Science, University of Sussex, BIAL foundation bursary “Microneurography as a tool for Consciousness Science.” Consulting (last three years): none. Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: Emteq Ltd. Unpaid governor on board of charity “Reflecting Nature in art & science.” Board of Directors: Co-director of Sackler Centre for Consciousness Science, University of Sussex. KES reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: German Research Council (DFG), Transregional Collaborative Research Centre, “Ingestive Behaviour: Homeostasis and Reward.” René and Susanne Braginsky Foundation. Consulting (last three years): none. Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: none. Board of Directors: none. Patents: none. Speakers Bureau: none. IVD reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: None. Consulting (last three years): none. Stockholder:

none. Scientific Advisory Boards: none. Board of Directors: none. Patents: none.

Speakers Bureau: none. LPS reports the following disclosures: Scientific Advisory Board: Laureate Institute for Brain Research, Inc. JDF reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: NIH R01MH105662, R21MH110865, and R01HD087712. Scientific Advisory Boards: International Obsessive-Compulsive Disorder Foundation Clinical and Scientific Advisory Board. JLR reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: NIH R01MD007807 and the Oklahoma Center for the Advancement of Science and Technology (OCAST) HR15-079. JSF reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: NIH/NIGMS P20GM121312, Brain and Behavior Foundation (formerly NARSAD) Young Investigator Award. Consulting (last three years): none.

Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: none. Board of Directors: none. Patents: none. Speakers Bureau: none. MBS reports the following disclosures: Scientific Advisory Board: Laureate Institute for Brain Research, Inc. Editorial Board: Depression and Anxiety, Biological Psychiatry. MPP reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: The William K Warren Foundation and the NIH R01DA016663, NIH/NIGMS P20DA027834, NIH R01DA027797, NIH R01DA018307, NIH U01DA041089, and NIH 1R01MH101453. Consulting (last three years): has received royalties for an article about methamphetamine use disorder from UpToDate. OGC reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: Research/Grants: none. Consulting (last three years): none.

Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: none. Board of Directors: none. Patents: none. Speakers Bureau: none. OVdB reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants: none. Consulting (last three years): none. Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: Research Training Group 2271 of the Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft (DFG) on

"Expectation Maintenance vs. Change in the Context of Expectation Violations:

Connecting Different Approaches", University of Marburg. Board of Directors: none.

Patents: none. Speakers Bureau: none. RDL reports the following disclosures:

Research/Grants: NIH. Consulting (last three years): none. Stockholder: none. Scientific

Advisory Boards: none. Board of Directors: none. Patents: none. SNG reports the

following disclosures: Research/Grants: none. Consulting (last three years): none.

Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: none. Board of Directors: none. Patents:

none. Speakers Bureau: none. SSK reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants:

NIH/NIMH K23MH112949, NIH/NIGMS P20GM121312, Brain and Behavior

Foundation (formerly NARSAD) Young Investigator Award. Consulting (last three

years): none. Stockholder: none. Scientific Advisory Boards: none. Board of Directors:

none. Patents: none. Speakers Bureau: none. WEM reports the following disclosures:

Research/Grants: NCIRE (Veterans Health Research Institute, San Francisco, California),

Alzheimer's Association, Mental Insight Foundation, The Pepper Foundation, UCSF

Resource Allocation Program. WKS reports the following disclosures: Research/Grants:

NIH P20GM121312, Brain and Behavior Foundation (formerly NARSAD) Young

Investigator Award. Consulting (last three years): none. Stockholder: none. Scientific

Advisory Boards: none. Board of Directors: none. Patents: none. Speakers Bureau: none.

The remaining authors report no biomedical financial interests or potential conflicts of interest.

Non-painful

Cardiovascular, respiratory, gastrointestinal (esophageal, gastric, intestinal, colorectal), bladder, hunger, thirst, blood/serum (pH, osmolality, glucose), temperature, vasomotor flush, air hunger, muscle tension, shudder, itch, tickle, genital sensation, sensual touch, fatigue

Painful

Visceral: kidney stone, pleuritic, angina, pericardial, bowel ischemia, pelvic, sickle crisis
Somatic: abscess/boil, bruising, myalgia, systemic/laceration inflammation, headache
Skeletal: fractured/bruised bone, stress fracture, inflammatory/mechanical joint pain

Table 1. Physiological processes often ascribed to interoception. Several key distinctions are that interoceptive sensing 1) may be painful or non-painful, 2) occurs across the spectrums of high/low arousal and negative/positive valence, 3) usually occurs outside of conscious awareness (with the exception of pain sensations), and 4) is often (but not always) consciously experienced during instances of homeostatic perturbation.

Feature	Definition
Attention	Observing internal body sensations
Detection	Presence or absence of conscious report
Magnitude	Perceived intensity
Discrimination	Localize sensation to a specific channel or organ system, and differentiate it from other sensations
Accuracy (Sensitivity)	Correct and precise monitoring
Insight	Metacognitive evaluation of experience/performance (e.g., confidence-accuracy correspondence)
Sensibility	Self-perceived tendency to focus on interoceptive stimuli. Trait measure.
Self-report scales	Psychometric assessment via questionnaire. State/trait measure.

Table 2. Features of interoceptive awareness. For some examples of paradigms assessing each feature see **Supplementary Table 1**.

Psychiatric disorder	Symptom	Sign	Sample studies
Panic disorder	Palpitations, chest pain, dyspnea, choking, nausea, dizziness, flushing, derealization or depersonalization	Elevated heart rate, blood pressure, exaggerated escape, startle, and flinching	(41-43)
Depression	Increased or decreased appetite, fatigue, lethargy	Weight gain, weight loss, psychomotor slowing	(44, 45)
Eating disorders	Severe food restriction, hunger insensitivity, food anxiety, gastrointestinal complaints	Severe weight loss, bingeing, purging, compulsive exercise	(46, 47)
Somatic symptom disorders	Multiple current physical and nociceptive symptoms	Medical observations do not correspond with symptom report	(48, 49)
Substance use disorders	Physical symptoms associated with craving, intoxication, and/or withdrawal (drug specific)	Elevated/decreased: heart rate, respiratory rate, blood pressure, pupil dilation/constriction, others (drug specific)	(50-52)
Posttraumatic stress disorder	Autonomic hypervigilance, derealization or depersonalization	Exaggerated startle, flinching, and escape responses, elevated heart rate, blood pressure	(53)
Generalized anxiety disorder	Muscle tension, headaches, fatigue, gastrointestinal complaints, pain	Trembling, twitching, shaking, sweating, nausea, exaggerated startle	(54, 55)
Depersonalization/derealization disorder	Detachment from one's body, head fullness, tingling, light headedness	Physiological hyporeactivity to emotional stimuli	(56, 57)
Autism spectrum disorders	Skin hypersensitivity	Selective clothing preferences	(58-60)

Table 3. Diagnostic symptoms and clinical signs indicative of interoceptive dysfunction in some psychiatric disorders.

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Figure legends

Figure 1. (A) Number of English language publications per year on interoception from Pubmed, Psychinfo and ISI Web of Knowledge. The timeline starts in 1905, one year before the publication of Charles Sherrington's book, "The integrative action of the nervous system," which first defined the concept of interoception. Key historical events relevant to interoception science are superimposed. (B) Publications per year on interoception, versus those investigating features of interoception that do not specifically refer to the term. These latter publications are more numerous, and arise mainly from basic neuroscience, physiology, and subspecialty disciplines within the biomedical field. Note the use of a logarithmic scale in the second panel. Figure reproduced and modified with permission from Khalsa & Lapidus (2016) (9).

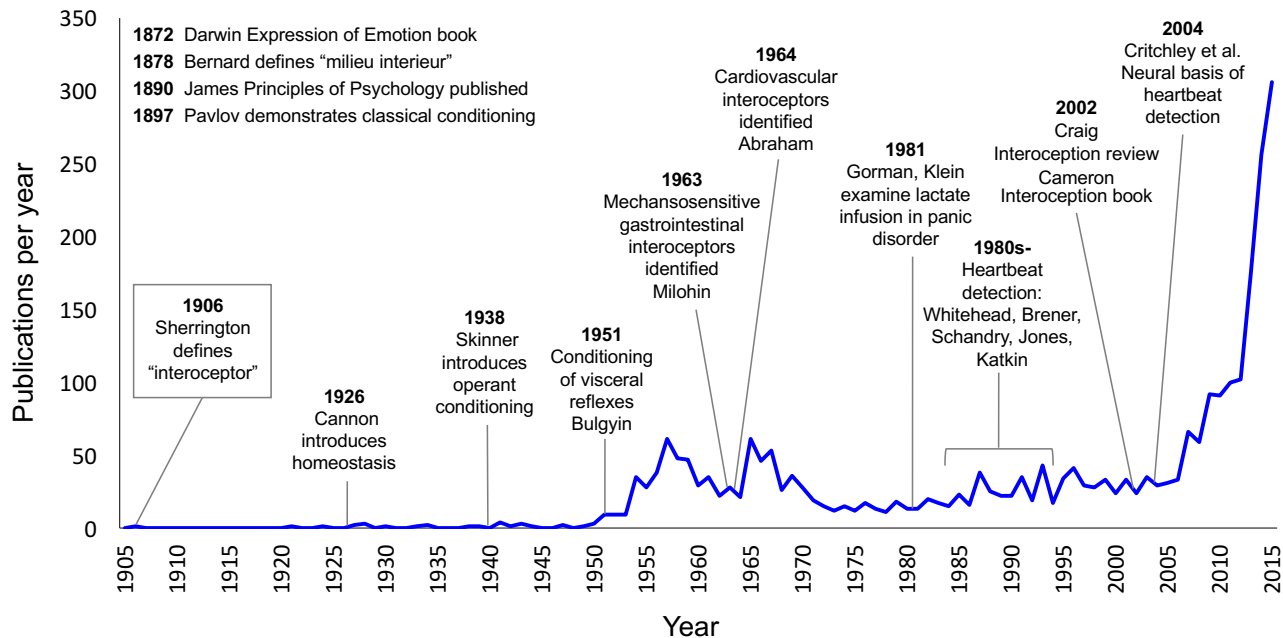
Figure 2. (A) Cardiac interoceptive processing measures and feature loading. This illustrates how the most commonly utilized heartbeat perception tasks differentially measure interoceptive features. Figure reproduced and modified with permission from Khalsa & Lapidus (2016) (9). (B) Multisystem interoceptive processing measures and feature loadings. Example of hypothetical approaches to measuring interoceptive processing across multiple systems. Approaches which perturb the state of the body are recommended, as well as convergent approaches, such as combined assessments of interoceptive attention and perturbation. (C) Central neural integration of interoceptive rhythms. Interoceptive rhythms vary considerably across the different systems of the

body. They exhibit complex characteristics, and are hierarchically integrated within discrete regions of the central nervous system. Figure modified with permission from Petzschner et al (2017) (39, 40). (D) Interoceptive rhythms vary in both amplitude and frequency. The top trace illustrates a hypothetical example of amplitude modulation signal superimposed on a static frequency. The middle trace illustrates a hypothetical frequency modulation signal superimposed on a static amplitude. The bottom trace illustrates a hypothetical signal change involving both amplitude and frequency modulations that are temporally correlated.

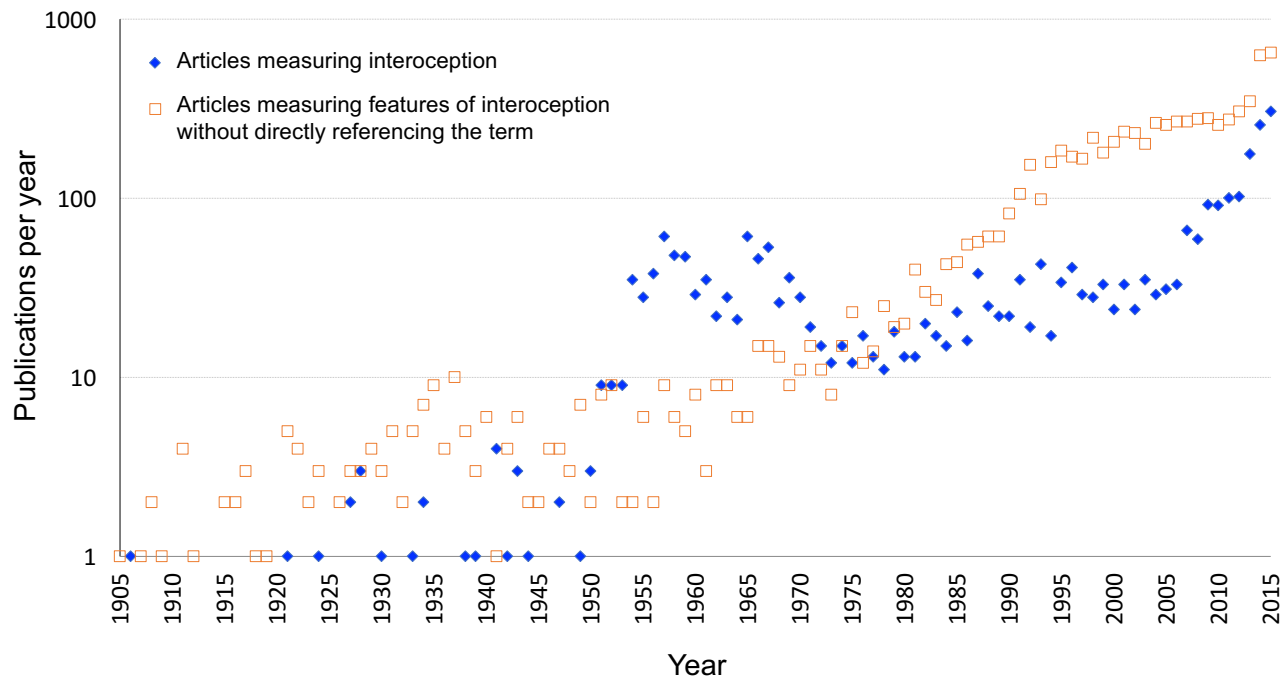
Figure 3. (A) Example of one possible form of a general inference-control loop illustrated within a hierarchical Bayesian model. (B) Highly schematic example of illustrating that both interoceptive and exteroceptive information are concurrently integrated to inform perceptual representations and action selection with respect to internally directed (e.g., visceromotor, autonomic) and externally directed (e.g., skeletomotor) actions. (C) General nodes which comprise a peripheral and central neural circuit for hierarchically integrating afferent interoceptive information into homeostatic reflexes, sensory and metacognitive representations, and allostatic regulators (predictions). ACC, anterior cingulate cortex; AIC, anterior insular cortex; MIC, mid-insular cortex; OFC, orbitofrontal cortex; PIC, posterior insular cortex; SGC, subgenual cortex. Figures reproduced, with permission, from Stephan et al (2016) (39) and Petzschner et al (2017) (40).

Figure 4. (A) Active inference implementation according to the Embodied Predictive Interoception Coding (EPIC) model. Agranular visceromotor cortices including the cingulate cortex, posterior ventral medial prefrontal cortex, posterior orbitofrontal cortex and the ventral anterior insula estimate the balance between autonomic, metabolic, and immunological resources available to the body, and its predicted requirements. These agranular visceromotor cortices issue allostatic predictions to hypothalamus, brainstem, and spinal cord nuclei to maintain a homeostatic internal milieu, and simultaneously to primary interoceptive sensory cortex in the mid and posterior insula. Interoceptive sensory cortex in the granular mid and posterior insula send reciprocal prediction error signals back to the agranular visceromotor regions to modify the predictions. Under usual circumstances these agranular regions are relatively insensitive to such feedback, which explains why interoceptive predictions are fairly stable in the face of body fluctuations. One hypothesis of the role of interoception in mental illness is that interoceptive input (i.e., posteriors) becomes increasingly decoupled from interoceptive predictions issued by agranular visceromotor cortex (priors), leading to increased interoceptive prediction error signals. This decoupling may present in the brain as “noisy afferent interoceptive inputs” (116). (B). Proposed intracortical architecture and intercortical connectivity for interoceptive predictive coding. Granular cortex contains six cell layers including granule cells, which are excitatory neurons that amplify and distribute thalamocortical inputs throughout the column. It is structurally similar to neocortex and therefore more recently evolved than the agranular and granular cortex. Within the insula, granular cortex is present in the mid and posterior sectors. AC, anterior cingulate; PL, prelimbic cortex. Figures reproduced, with permission, from Barrett & Simmons (2015) (67).

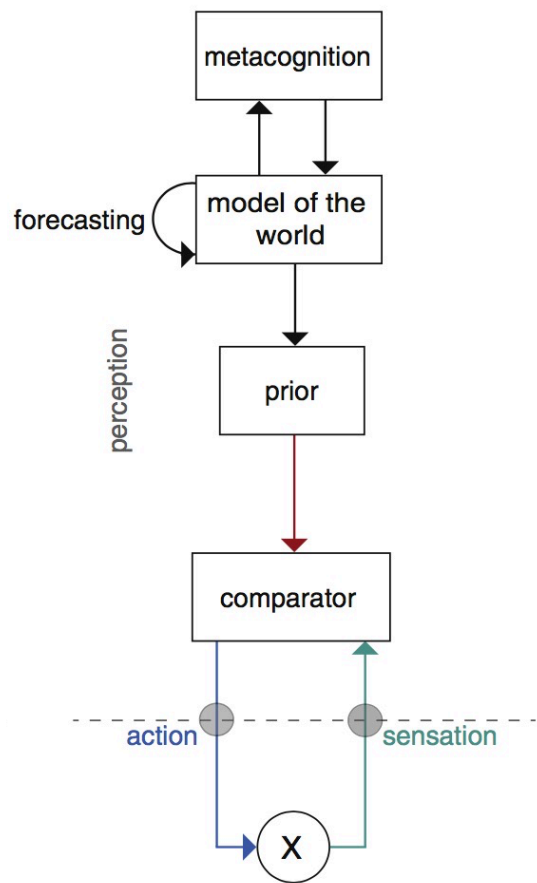
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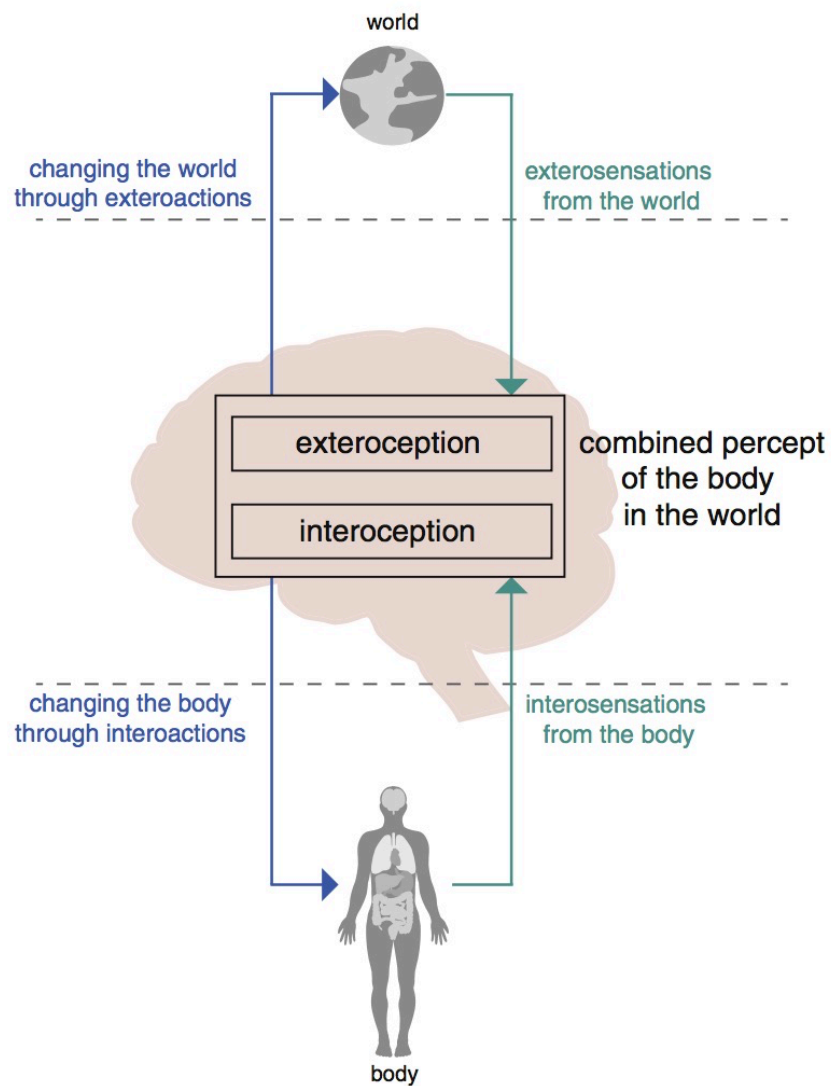
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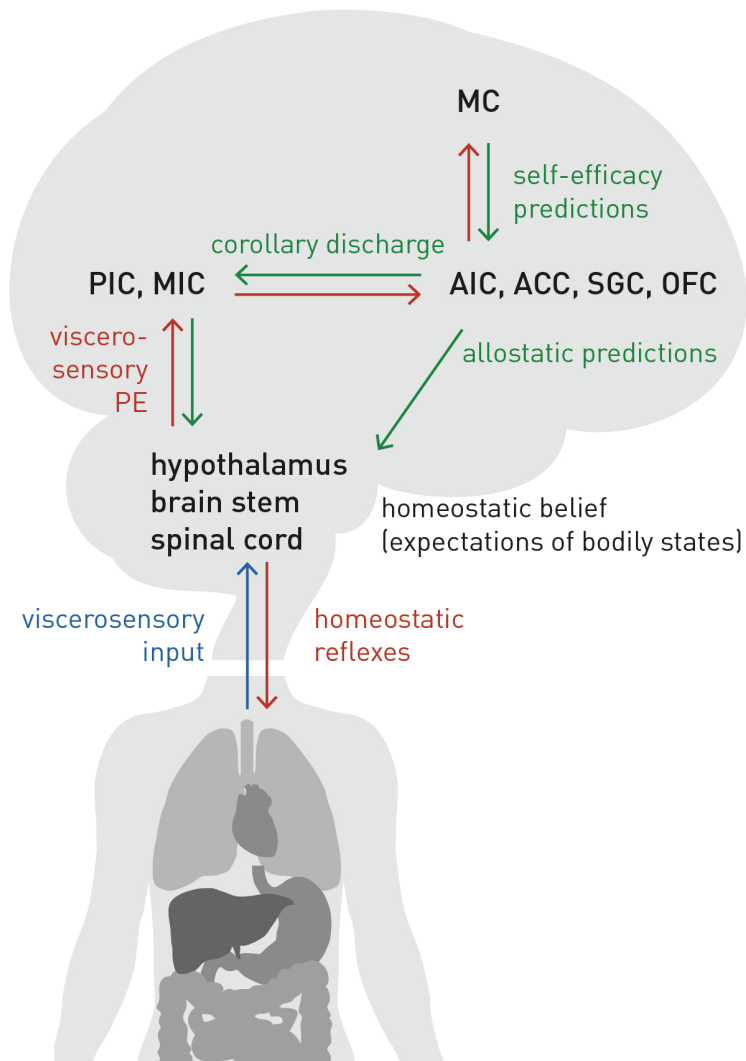
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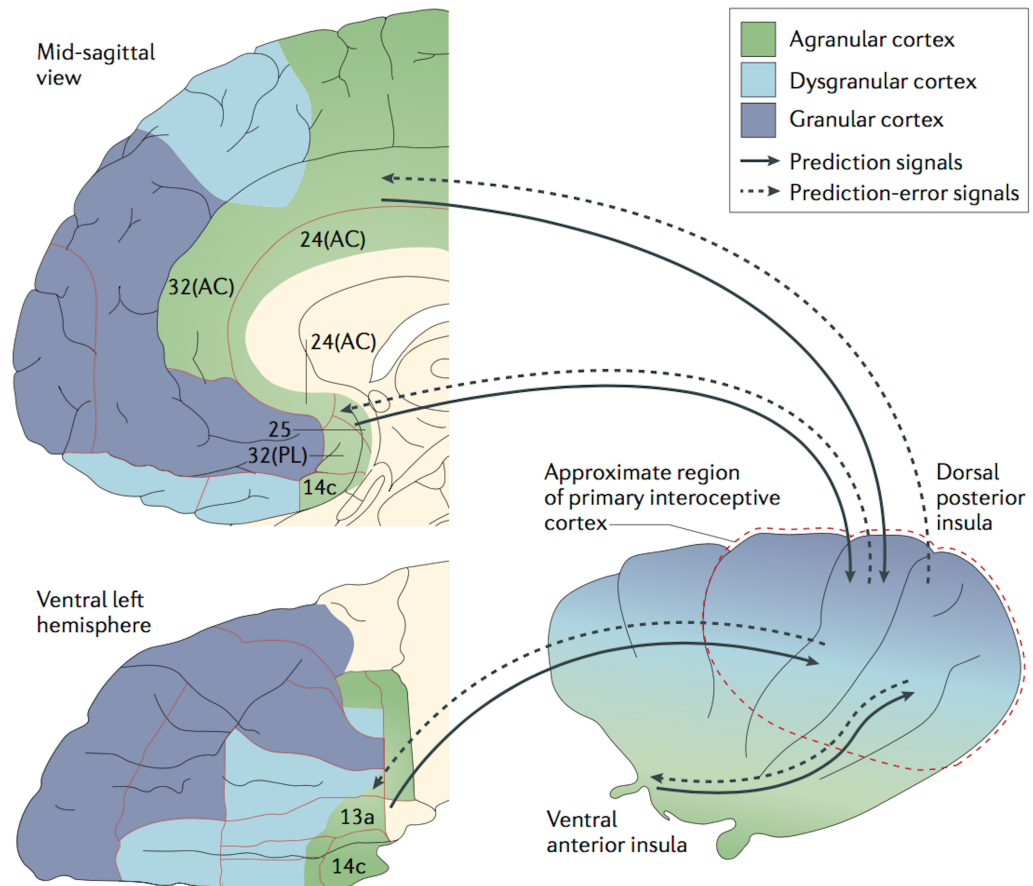
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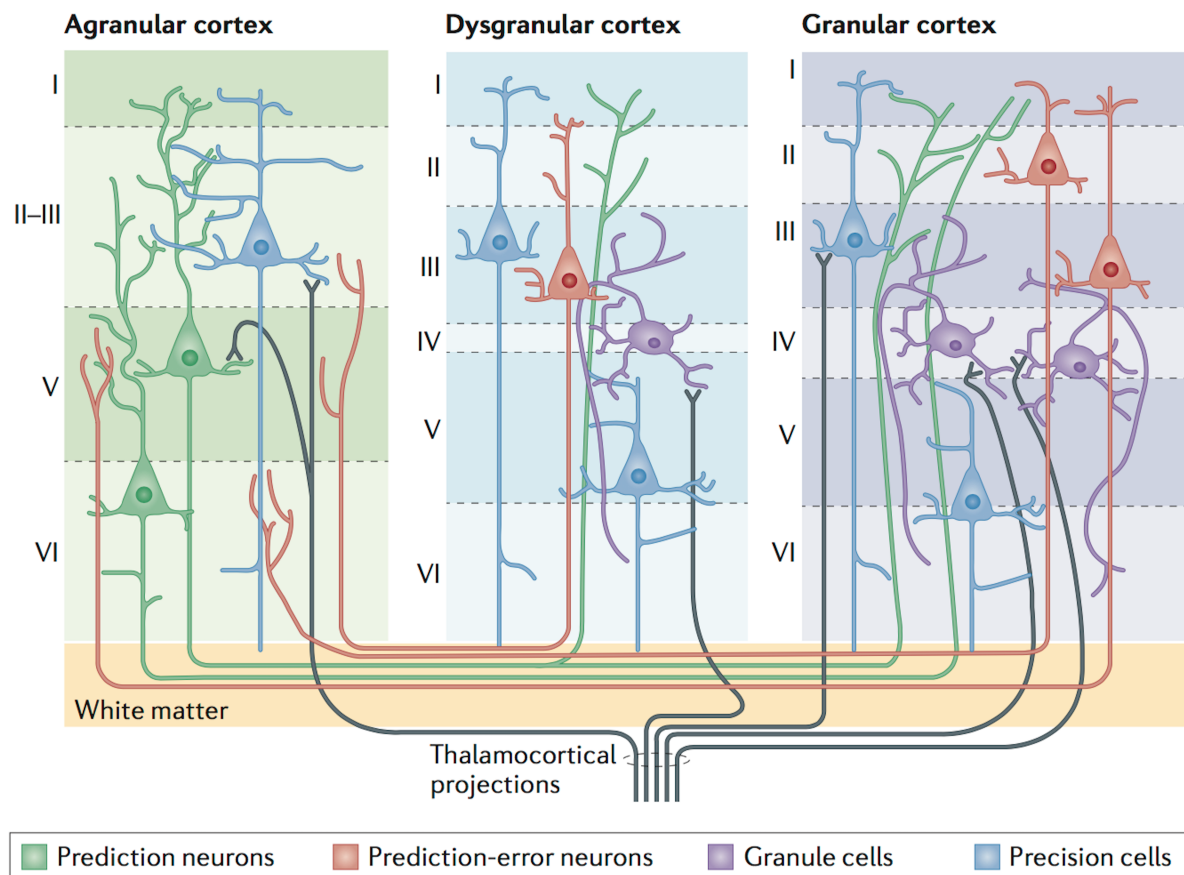
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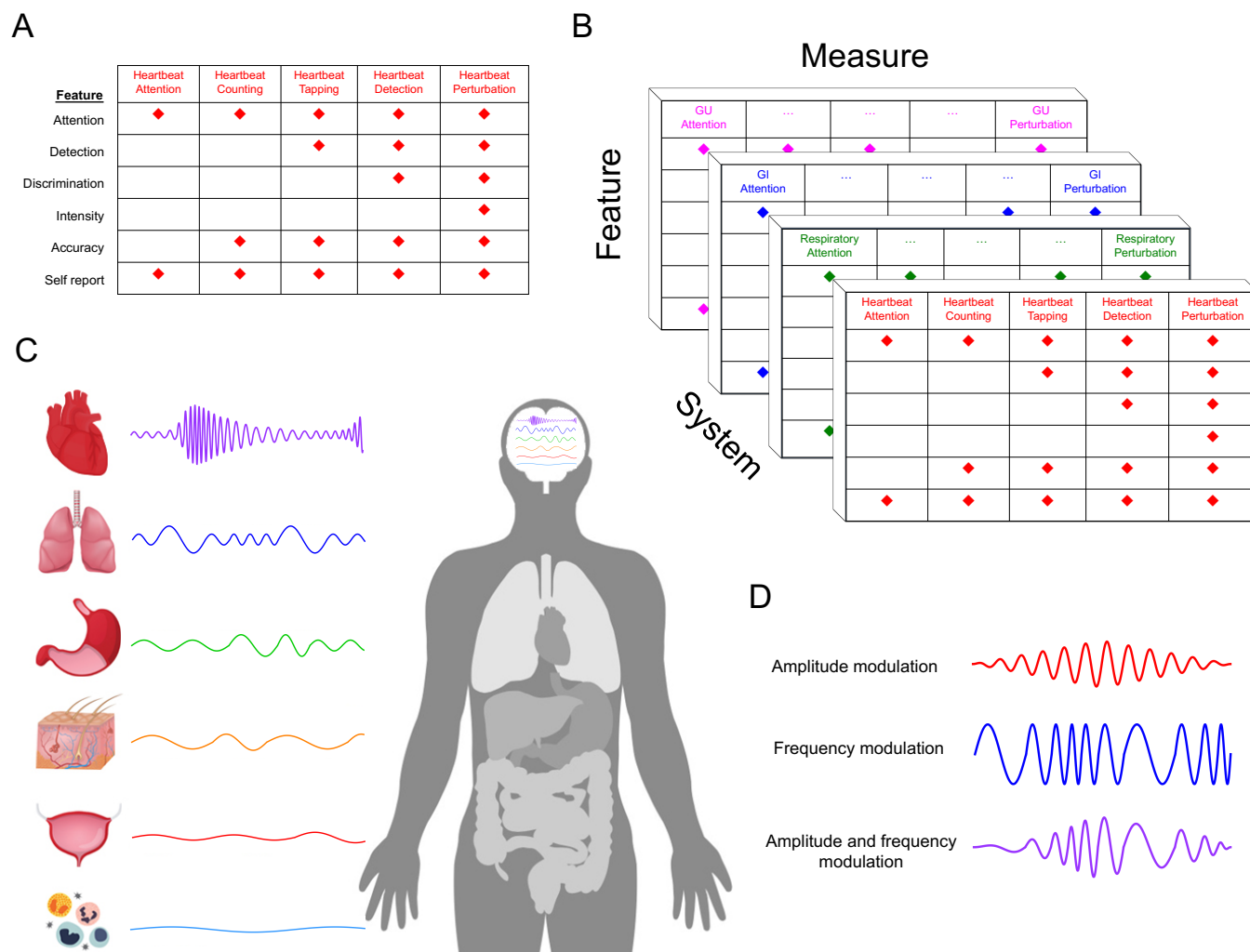


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B





Interoception and Mental Health: A Roadmap

Supplemental Information

Feature	Definition	Paradigms
Attention	Observing internal body sensations	C, GI (Simmons et al., 2013) R (Farb et al., 2013)
Detection	Presence or absence of conscious report	C (Khalsa et al., 2008) C (Garfinkel et al., 2013) R (Davenport et al., 2007) R (Paulus et al., 2012) GI (Holzl et al., 1996)
Magnitude	Perceived intensity	C, R (Khalsa et al., 2009b) R (Davenport et al., 2007) GI (Herbert et al., 2012b) GI (Naliboff et al., 2006) U (Jarrahi et al., 2015)
Discrimination	Localize sensation to a specific channel or organ system, and differentiate it from other sensations	C, R (Khalsa et al., 2015) GI (Aziz et al., 2000)
Accuracy (sensitivity)	Correct and precise monitoring	C (Schandry et al., 1993) C, R (Khalsa et al., 2009a) R (Daubenmier et al., 2013) GI (Zaman et al., 2016)
Insight	Metacognitive evaluation of experience/performance (e.g., confidence-accuracy correspondence)	(Khalsa et al., 2008) (Garfinkel et al., 2015)
Sensibility	Self-perceived tendency to focus on interoceptive stimuli. Trait measure.	(Garfinkel et al., 2015) (Garfinkel et al., 2016)
Self-report scales	Psychometric assessment via questionnaire. State/trait measure.	(Shields et al., 1989) (Porges, 1993) (Labus et al., 2007) (Mehling et al., 2012)

Supplementary Table S1. Features of interoceptive awareness. The illustrated paradigms span several physiological systems including the cardiac (C), respiratory (R), gastrointestinal (GI), and urinary (U) systems. Note that the paradigms and references listed here are not exhaustive; they are provided as illustrative examples. Many other approaches and paradigms exist, some of which are described in the main manuscript.

Interoception taxonomy

Interoception: The overall process of how the nervous system senses, integrates, stores, and represents information about the state of the inner body at conscious and unconscious levels. It is important to note that the contemporary definition of interoception is not synonymous with the term visceroreception, but it does subsume it. Visceroreception classically refers to the perception of bodily signals arising specifically from visceral organs such as the heart, lungs, stomach, intestines, and bladder, along with other internal organs in the trunk of the body (1). Visceroreception does not include organs like the skin or skeletal muscle, whereas interoception encompasses both visceral signaling and more broadly relates to all physiological tissues that relay a signal to the central nervous system about the current state of the body, including the skin and skeletal/smooth muscle fibers, via lamina I spinothalamic afferents (2-4).

Interoceptive awareness: Conceptualizations of interoceptive awareness have been rather diverse. The term was originally introduced in 1983 by Garner and colleagues (5), via the development of the ‘interoceptive awareness’ subscale, part of a self-report measure intended to assess eating disorder symptom severity. The items on the subscale were derived based on the clinicians’ experience, as well as prior empirical work on ‘gastric perceptivity’ in eating disorders (6). However, only 2 of the 10 items actually assessed interoception-related symptoms (“I get confused as to whether or not I am hungry” and “I feel bloated after eating a small meal”), with the remainder of the subscale preferentially measuring alexithymia (e.g., “I get confused about what emotion I am feeling”). Ensuing publications over the next 20 years referred to interoceptive awareness in this context (1983-2004, a total of 51 in PubMed). Following a report by Critchley

et al. (2004) entitled “Neural systems supporting interoceptive awareness” (7), it has subsequently been used to encompass any (or all) of the different interoception features accessible to conscious self-report (2004-present, 288 publications in PubMed) (8). A more coherent and precise terminology has now been developed to describe its various components (Supplementary Table S1).

Interoceptive attention: The ability to direct attentional resources towards the source of internal body sensations. It can be captured (i.e., triggered involuntarily) in a stimulus dependent or ‘bottom up’ manner (9, 10), or shifted purposefully in a goal directed or ‘top down’ manner (11, 12). There is an important distinction about attentional ‘styles’, which may be viewed on a spectrum of anxiety driven, evaluative/avoidant on one extreme, to mindful, non-judgmental, and accepting on the other (13). The latter style tends to be cultivated during clinical applications of mindfulness and other forms of meditative practice.

Interoceptive detection: The ability to detect the presence or absence of a stimulus. It is a binary variable, similar to detection of a light source when it is switched on or off, or a judgment about whether a river is flowing or not.

Interoceptive magnitude: The intensity with which an internal bodily event is perceived. It is therefore a stimulus parameter reflecting the amount of signal. It is a continuous variable, e.g., reflecting how much dyspnea is present, and is typically gauged via subjective reports from the individual using rating scales, for example visual analogue scales and numerical rating scales. Magnitude estimation has been explained as a combination of prior expectations and current

sensory input (14), emphasizing its relevance for Hierarchical Bayesian Models (HBMs) of interoception. It is difficult to measure changes in this feature in the absence of physiological perturbations (15).

Interoceptive discrimination: An individual's ability to localize sensation within a specific interoceptive system and to differentiate it from non-interoceptive sensations. It often requires the ability to locate sensations to specific regions within the body (as opposed to elsewhere inside the body), or relative to an external signal. Examples include the ability to distinguish a feeling of fullness after a meal from an irritating cough, or from the noise of a television in the background. It may also require the ability to separate different sensations from within the same interoceptive source, for example, as occurs when swallowing a food bolus (proximal vs. distal esophageal sensation and subsequent gastric deposition).

Interoceptive accuracy: The ability to precisely and correctly monitor changes in internal body state. It is synonymous with interoceptive sensitivity, and it has been the most commonly studied feature of interoception. Typical approaches involve the simultaneous measurement of an objective marker (e.g., heart rate, degree of inspiratory breathing load), the subjective experience of the individual (e.g., counted heart rate, detection or intensity of breathing difficulty), and subsequent calculation of the relationship between them. Subjective variables may be dichotomous (e.g., sensation present or absent, as in interoceptive detection) or continuous (e.g. how intense the stimulus is, as in interoceptive magnitude or discrimination). The interoceptive stimuli that are attended to may be acutely punctuated (as in the heartbeat) or continuous and prolonged (as in gut or bladder fullness). Interoceptive accuracy necessarily depends upon interoceptive attention given

the reliance on attentional mechanisms for generating accuracy estimates. Common measurement examples include: 1) d' for heartbeat detection tasks (a signal detection metric (16, 17), cardiac error score for heartbeat counting tasks (18, 19), 2) cross correlations between heart rate and dial tracings of perceived intensity following adrenergic infusion (8, 20), 3) percent accuracy for detection of breathing occlusion (21), 4) intraclass correlations between bladder volumes and urinary urge (22), and 5) cross correlations between respiratory trace and slider tracings of the perceived phase and depth of respiration (23).

Interoceptive insight: The metacognitive measure detailing the correspondence between subjective experience and behavior. This is most typically evaluated by assessing the correspondence between accuracy and performance confidence on specific tasks. For example, in a study in which experienced meditators did not have different interoceptive accuracy on a heartbeat detection task, they exhibited differences in interoceptive self-report, reporting that the task was easier and their performance was improved relative to nonmeditators (24). In another study, performance on a heartbeat counting task was positively correlated with self-reported confidence estimates only in individuals with high but not low interoceptive accuracy scores (25) (note that replacement of the term ‘interoceptive awareness’ with ‘interoceptive insight’ in the prior study (25) is in keeping with the more coherent nomenclature suggested in this consensus statement).

Interoceptive sensibility: The self-perceived dispositional tendency to focus on interoceptive stimuli across daily life. Assessments of this trait measure inherently require an evaluation of self-perceived tendencies across broad time spans. This is commonly assessed by asking individuals to

reflect on their autobiographical experience by answering questions such as ‘To what extent do you believe you focus on and detect internal bodily sensations?’ (25, 26). Mehling (13) has argued that the measurement of interoceptive sensibility is substantially more complex than the approach employed by Garfinkel *et al.* (25), particularly as the rating does not capture the regulatory and accepting/non-judgmental aspects of experience that are relevant for clinical settings. To address this complexity Mehling (13) developed the Multidimensional Assessment of Interoceptive Awareness (MAIA), which assesses 8-items via self-report (Noticing, Not-Distracting, Not-Worrying, Attention Regulation, Emotional Awareness, Self-Regulation, Body Listening, and Trusting) (see next section).

Interoceptive self-report scales: The ability to reflect upon one’s autobiographical experiences of interoceptive states, make judgments about their outcomes, and describe them through verbal or motor responses. It is most commonly assessed experimentally using instruments or scales and there are a variety of them (25, 27-30). There are likely to be many constructs that can be identified within this level. For example, it may be possible to investigate dissociations between an individual’s self-report of their interoceptive experiences versus their partner report (e.g., someone who knows the participant well and has had regular opportunities to interact with and observe them in a variety of situations, an approach that has been utilized for neurological samples (31)). Accordingly, the self-report component may be viewed as one of the most complex and nuanced features awaiting further investigation.

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Eric	Breese	Laureate Institute for Brain Research	
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Kaiping	Burrows	Laureate Institute for Brain Research	
Yoon-Hee	Cha	Laureate Institute for Brain Research	
Ashley	Clausen	Laureate Institute for Brain Research	
Kelly	Cosgrove	Laureate Institute for Brain Research	
Danielle	Deville	Laureate Institute for Brain Research	
Laramie	Duncan	Stanford University	
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Hamed	Ekhtiari	Laureate Institute for Brain Research	
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